

Managing creative projects: An empirical synthesis of activities

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Abstract

This paper proposes a radical empirical look on the concrete activities of project managers involved in creative projects, with a specific focus on “non-administrative” issues. Through four case studies in the video-game industry, multimedia, advertising and a circus, we propose an integrated synthesis of what creative project managers actually do. Beyond analytical, cognitive, psychological, symbolic and discursive activities, we identify four sets of activities carefully coined to acknowledge the everyday work of project manager involved in creative projects. We suggest that this project manager acts as a *sense-maker*, a *web-weaver*, a *game-master* and a *flow-balancer*. This empirical “picture” raises questions on the technical and theoretical focus of research in project management where creativity is an utmost strategic issue.

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1. The creative imperative

In the first issue of this journal, Blankevoort suggested that “tools should be developed for the management of creativity to make project management complete as a recognized profession” [1]. Researchers and practitioners as well provided numerous answers to this call, in the form of general management approaches [2,3], creativity-inducing methods [4,5] and techniques [6]. Yet, little has been said on what project managers actually do to lead creative teams.

As our business world is shifting from a knowledge-based to a conception/design-based economy [7], creative projects are becoming a strategic necessity [8]. Managers and leaders are getting more concerned about the management of creative endeavours [9]. In this regard, it has been suggested that construction and product-development projects ask for different work processes, especially from the psychosocial point of view [10]. In “Design-Oriented Organizations” [11], the mobilisation of collective knowledge

through projects is essential. In projects where ambiguity increases and goals are only broadly/partially defined, collective creativity has to be fostered, channelled and managed. Beyond the interesting practical and theoretical issues on creativity skills and methods [12–18], the managerial [19,20] or structural approaches to foster creativity in individuals and groups [21–24] and the literature on creative leadership [2,25] or best practices in the management of creativity for innovation [6,26–28], less has been empirically done to assess how project managers concretely handle individual and collective creativity in projects.

In this regard, this paper aims at introducing the activities of project managers involved in creative projects in a non-abstract, non-theoretical way, with a strong focus on describing what they actually do. After a short theoretical introduction and some brief methodological considerations, the core of the paper presents an empirical “picture” based on field data from various creative industries. It is argued that the project manager engages in sets of activities coined as *sense-maker*, *web-weaver*, *game-master* and *flow-balancer* (see Fig. 1). Those activities and categories are discussed with further reflections on the management of creativity in projects.

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